Moon

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35649253.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Double Trouble & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

Characters:
Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Original Characters, Double Trouble (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fantasizing, Lucid Dreaming, Night Terrors, Imagination, Monsters, Swordfighting, Childhood Memories, Childhood, Future Fic, Childhood Friends, Trauma, Childhood Trauma, Fantasy, Immaturity, Loss of Innocence, Innocence, War, Post-War, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Family, Friendship, Ocean, Painting, Love

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English

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Part 2 of Tales from the Puny World

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by Nexus_Nexus

Summary

Finn, the moon of Catra and Adora, grapples with their past and present as they recount their life moments before it ends. No matter what, it all circles back to Aislin, the princess of Bright Moon, their best friend in life and death.

Nighttime Fighttime (introduction)

This empty hallway is not much, but I can try to work with it. I leveled my wooden sword, a gift given by an odd family friend. The stark white walls and gigantic windows slowly gave way to a clouded night sky and a vast stretch of marshland. It was perfect.

The glow of fireflies hangs in the dry air of the night, deep into the season of summer, their small pinpricks of light replacing the stars that are covered by dense dark clouds. All is silent in the swamp, no wind to move the leaves, no fish to push the water, not even a frog dares croak. The heartbeat of a mouse would be loud enough to hear from the top of a tree if there were any mice around to begin with. A single cricket scuttles around in the foliage, too petrified to try and call out to find a mate. No one would be moving tonight. From the depths of the mud and slime, a creature emerges, barely visible through all of the plants around it. But as it becomes taller and taller and taller, it is impossible to ignore. With scales as sharp as words and eyes red with the color of the finest cake, surely not a soul on the planet could take it down. At least that's what it thinks to itself, proud enough to let out a terrible roar louder than a thunderclap. Any animal that was near it no longer remains, as they have all run away for their puny little lives. All but one. Finn the Great, the Mighty, the Spectacular, lurks in the bushes just beyond the creature's vision. Their sword is sharp and longer than their own body, but it is deadly. The awful creature teetered and tottered, unmoving, as if waiting for any foolish challenger to come and try to bring it down. Unlucky for it, there was indeed a challenger tonight. Finn lifted the sword high above their head and swung down with a tremendous force, the air around the blade quivering and crackling with excitement. Every fiber of every muscle in their body was on fire, snapping out of their dormant positions and exploding towards the foul terror that lurked directly ahead. As the sword came down on the monster's back, Finn screamed with a roar loud enough to mock the one made only seconds before it, as if trying to compete with

the creature. Finally, after what seemed like ages, the edge of the weapon lodged into the back of the beast, but it went no further. A shockwave blasted through the swamp, sending both Finn and the monster he had attacked tumbling down into the water. The monster was still trying to regain its balance, but Finn was already swimming, on a mission, towards the sword that was still stuck. Black blood oozed out from under it, the smell almost too pungent to bear. Flowers and tallgrass wilted as it spread, making Finn's eyes water. Still determined, they reached for the hilt, the beast still lurching around in the water, trying to regain its footing, and pulled it back out. Bits of skin and guts flew everywhere as the monster fell over once again, now screaming with an agonizing fear in its voice. Finn stood to their feet, rising above the murky water and mud below them, and raised the sword once more. The creature looked up at them, unwilling to resist what would inevitably come next. Finn grinned, so little that one standing next to them would not see it, and the sword made its way up to the sky once more. This time, it would not fail its mission. The moonlight reflected off of the blade, making it gleam in an unnervingly beautiful way. The creature closed its eyes and stopped moving around, waiting for the sweet embrace of darkness to end its suffering. Finn was happy to oblige. Their arms swiped down faster than you could blink your eyes, or even try to protest. The head of the beast flew out of the water, the body melting back into dirt, then mud, then dust, then gone.

I raised my sword high above my head and let out a triumphant scream, only to stop myself. *Don't wake them up, they will be mad.* The empty, long, impossibly large hallway bounced the sound of my victory off of every wall with perfect clarity. Slowly, but surely, it dissipated and no one woke. No one rose to yell at me or put me in trouble. I was free.

Hope and What it Means

I don't remember being born. It was so long ago now, that I just don't know what it was like. When you get older and older and time spirals out of control, the early days just blend together and you can't tell which is which. Aislin says she remembered being born, which I thought was a lie but she was smarter than me so I couldn't argue. She often said she knew all of these things, like why the sky is blue or how fireflies glow or where babies come from. I'd ask her to tell me sometimes, but she would just say "you'll learn when you're grown up," like I wasn't only a year younger than she was. She drove me insane sometimes but there was very little company in the palace, other than my parents and the staff of course. Hanging out with her to pass the boredom eventually became hanging out with her because I wanted to. We both loved to sprint around the kitchen and steal food from the chefs, and since Aislin was a princess they couldn't do anything to us if they caught us. We practically were the same person after a few years, going everywhere and doing everything together. We were like the moons in the sky, except there are three moons and only two of us. Actually, that metaphor makes no sense, but regardless, we were attached at the waist. Inseparable.

We shared a private tutor together, he never told us his name so we called him whatever names we wanted, and he hated us with a furiosity so burnt I could see it even back then. We would often derail whatever lesson he was trying to teach us about grammar or mathematics or science and make funny jokes or paper airplanes while he spoke. Aislin once sculpted a sheet of homework so masterfully that if thrown it could spin like a corkscrew directly to wherever she aimed it. One day, it was aimed directly for the back of the teacher's head, and it did not miss.

"You two are little devils!" he would say to us, and we would always snicker and come back with a cheeky statement. Once I asked him to spell D-E-V-I-L for us, once she told him that we didn't know what devils were because he was a bad teacher.

"You're lucky I'm getting paid," was a regular remark when it came to our classes. Two hours a day felt like two lifetimes when we were trying to be taught something important.

One thing that we did learn, however, was how to draw. The tutor would take a breather every two days and the gardener would come in with a pair of plants that we would then get to draw. Gradually, the images became less blobby and more realistic, imitating the nature that laid in front of our eyes. Drawing, the gardener would say, was more like translation than it was artistry. Either translating visuals from your eyes or thoughts from your head. If your imagination was good enough, you didn't have to even see anything to translate it down into a picture, you could just think of it. I could think of the plants he gave us and draw them outside of class, something I did quite often. Aislin seemed to like it, but not as much as she did other forms of art like music. After a while, I got good enough at drawing the plants that I could think of my own plants and draw those instead. They were not the best drawings in the world by a long shot, as my hand-eye coordination had a lot to desire, but the imagination inside of me was becoming more focused on what it was trying to do. I still would think it was odd that the gardener knew more about art than the teacher did, since his whole job was to *teach* us, but I liked him more. He had kind eyes and a soft, deep voice that was nothing like the high warble of the terrible tutor. We never learned his name either, but instead of calling him whatever we wanted, we would call him Gardener. He seemed just fine with that.

But then the days that were not art days were the normal two hours of hell that we had to traverse. Back to paper airplanes and silly names and little devils. That's what we liked to call ourselves: Little Devils. We knew it was not meant as a compliment, but we claimed it for ourselves and it became our fuel. I once engraved *LD* onto my desk after class, something the teacher was not happy about when he came in the next day. At every turn we made sure to remind him of the title he came up for us, an eternal, self-given punishment that he dealt with for two years. And then one day he left.

Aislin's mom was incredibly mad at us, and so was Mama Adora. They took us aside the day after he quit and scolded us for a good few minutes before sending us off to help the kitchen staff clean up after lunch. Mams Catra seemed a little bit proud of me, but wasn't showing it for some reason. Subtly, though, she reached out her hand for a high-five, and I took it with a grin. While Mama Adora would lecture me about the "consequences of my own actions" or my "effect on other people", I would just think of that high-five and know I was doing the right thing.

It was after this that the tutoring was put on hold for a while, around two months, while they put out a call for another scholar to take up the terrible work of teaching two Little Devils. We would have free reign to play around the castle instead of learn about multiplication and what type of rock "sedimentary" was, if that was even a real thing. We would still learn, the palace library was interesting enough to ensure that, but now under our own rules rather than those of a tutor. Walking around the massive skyscrapers filled with books and tomes, containing every bit of knowledge we had and never would get to gain, was nothing short of a dream for us. I liked finding the best paintings or books filled with lots of pictures, as they reminded me of how pretty art could be. Aislin would always roam to the music section and find books on how to read or write music. She would spend hours sitting there, looking at the books without even addressing my presence. When she did that, I would just pick up a random book I thought had a pretty cover and start absorbing the figures. The words were alright, but they weren't what was important. Except for the time when we found a particularly new book, fresh off the cart from Aislin's dad's family, all about the ancient languages of the cultures that were long since dead by our time. It struck our attention first because of the beautiful printing on the face, spine, and organs, but then another tidbit jumped out at us. On the second page was the word that we both knew better than anyone, *Aislin: An ancient First-One's term meaning "hope"*. Hope. That was what her name would have been if we were one-thousand years older.

At her funeral, her mother told us that she was named Hope because of the bright future ahead of the world. It had just come out of a long period of turmoil and ignorance, only to be graced with color and peace. And then Hope died. Alone. Freezing.

I found a book one day that had an odd appearance. Instead of a name or title, it only had a dark green cover with a white outline of a pine cone (something that Gardener brought in once for us to draw). Opening it up, it became immediately clear that I must own the book, because it was filled to the brim with images of plants. The author, a name I do not remember, had apparently traveled to every kingdom and every reach of the globe, searching for common and rare plants to draw and classify. None of them had color, but the descriptions added all of the vibrancy they needed for me to fall in love. Flipping the pages, I would find a picture that I liked and copy it, translating every single stroke of the pencil that the unknown artist had made when translating the plants before I had even been born. It was not a new book, but not old either. It was new enough to speak of odd Glow Daisies, or *Leucanthemum Lumine,* as the small writing on the side told me, which were only made because of toxic glowy chemicals from the waste on Beast Island. It was not new enough to note that the island had recently stopped existing. Aislin and I read through the pages, one by one, until the sun ran out it's clock and we were forced back to bed. In the middle of the night, as agreed, we snuck back into the library and found the book, all under the dim glow of a candle. We brought blankets and pillows to ward off the cold hands of winter, matches in case the flame burnt out, and glowing eyes fit to replace the moons in the sky above our heads. We laid on our stomachs, the book propped up in front of us, and read. No words, no whispers, no promises, just drawings of plants. Perhaps it was something about them being so different to the sleek, undying look of the palace, or perhaps it was simply the new shapes that we had never seen before, but nature encapsulated both of us and brought us into a world far beyond the scope of our own.

A world that would last for two more years before it died. Alone. Freezing.

Mother (interlude)

"Oh once upon a dreadful wintertime. The winds were a-howlin' the kids were dying. But on came the mother, the savior, the lover. She brought us far away from the cold dark vines!"

Verse after verse, the song would draw me in, telling tales of the days after or before the war, written by our mothers, fathers, and ancestors. It sure made the sea less boring.

"The bridge 'cross the mouth of the river wide, was crumblin' and humblin' against the tides. But on came the mother, the savior, the lover. She fixed right up the path toward a cold dark sight!"

I would often wonder if these stories were real or not, or just the General making it up as he went. The maritime mania could get to anyone, forcing nonsense out of their mouths at a maddening pace. Maybe that was what this was: madness.

"The mountains far above stretched too high to see. The jungle to our left did align the sea. So on went the mother, the savior, the lover. She guided our tribe down as easy as could be!"

It was hard to believe a story such as this one, seemingly religious in nature, but there were far weirder ones that had really happened. Women disappearing, paintings being devoured into nothing, glowing flowers causing death, everything about my life was strange enough to fit into a song like this one.

"The birds flying yonder screamed aloud. The words that we pondered escaped our mouths. And that's when the mother, the savior, the lover, came up to us and simply said 'Okay! I'm headed out!'"

Such a whimsical tune should have brought me to my feet in dance but I was too far lost in my own melody. In my own mother.

Far-Awayedness

The waves are calm today. It's moments like these, an utter lack of movement from any source, when I am the most on edge. The sun was not yet visible but its light made the world glow a deep blue, the blanket of clouds above echoing the sea below. A box on six sides of water, fog, and clouds made the planet seem impossibly small, even shrouding the creature below me in darkness. The general hadn't yet awoken but his son walked up the stairs and onto the deck beside me. The barely audible, barely moving wind made me shiver, but not enough that he would notice. Summer was waning and so was the heat, but it was far from being cold out on the tropical waters only a couple miles from Salineas. The boat, previously feeling steady as a boulder on the shore, rocked enough for me to feel every centimeter on each side. I was aware of every lap of water against the greenish-tinted metal, their whispers filling my ears along with the slight caress of the wind. The sails flapped and cracked quietly above my head, further boxing me in along with the water, fog, and clouds. I was, on all sides, on all fronts, in all essence, surrounded.

"Morning" he said, unaware of how out of place the calm gesture sounded to me.

I weakly replied with a hello, and then went back to staring out into the nothing and listening to the everything. I listened to the lack of fish swarming underneath the waves, the wood creaking underneath his uneven stance, his mouth opening but not his vocal chords. I didn't know what he wanted to say, but he must have had some thought that he never finished. Instead, he wired his jaw shut and the wood creaked all along the path he took right next to me. Leaning against the railing, precariously angled over the deathly depths, he mimics my far-awayedness. I can tell he was thinking something very loudly, but was letting it pour past his thin skin, a pure, silky membrane that I had become familiar with over the course of this long journey by boat. A journey that was set to end today.

The dry crunching of the last few ration bars struck the silence like lightning, both of us stuck in this storm of awkwardness that always ensues after a moment of ferocity. We eagerly avoid eye contact, fearful of the look that the other will give us, a look that could reveal too much or too little emotion. We're wrapped up in two separate blankets, something we would usually skip for just one larger one, but such an action would literally make me die right now, figuratively speaking. I decide to turn my head slightly towards him and catch a movement of his own in the opposite direction. I know he was staring at me, probably lost in the same thought I'm dredging through. He seems pensive but alert, as if panicking while trying to look put together. The far-awayedness dissipates with his posture and he sighs as if deflating.

"Finn?"

"Yeah?"

"Can I ask you something... kinda dumb?"

"Well that happens every time you pose me a question," I tried to deflect with humor, and he did laugh, but I realized I don't want to come off as rude. "But yes, ask away."

His slight smile falls back down into the water. "Are we... is this a thing?" His skin is turning an exotic shade of red. I don't know the answer but I have to look collected. "I mean, I don't know your feelings- uh, or..." he stammers quite a bit when he's nervous. "Y'know, we just have always- well last night, I..." He was embarrassing himself but I couldn't help finding it endearing. I want him to just shut up, and at this point I'm pretty sure how I feel.

As I lean in to kiss him, I can watch in slow motion everything that can go wrong in an instant happen at once. I watch as the General, his father, crests the top of the stairs only a few places from his son and the moon of She-ra making a move on him. I watch as the ship rocks forward suddenly, going against the grain of the calm waves from before, sending almost everything that

wasn't bolted down flying. I watch as the oil lamp the General carried flies to the wooden floor, immediately shattering and setting ablaze. I just wanted one kiss, but the universe and her precious little entropy had other plans.

Charged with adrenaline and confusion, three naked souls dive from their spots to look over at what caused their ship to suddenly be on fire. Not finding any luck, I sprint belowdecks to find the fire-trapping blanket that was designed by Entrapta, the genius herself. Truly an amazing creation, one I could ramble for hours about if I was not currently trying to put out a fire on the boat I am sailing in. Entrapta is one of the most brilliant minds on this whole planet, even at her age. I've met her a few times before, mostly when I was a child, but her inventions have fueled my interest more than most anything else. Especially this fire blanket that I have to throw onto our flaming ship, the source of the lurching rounding back for another shot.

The mountain of awkward feelings was burned to the ground, the sense of panic setting in to take its place. The submarine was quick, quicker than any other one we had seen them piloting before today. Its blackened steel exoskeleton was barely visible through the thick slop surrounding it, but the General's eye was trained and our weapons were strong. I felt the jutting force of the engine firing for the first time in a week, finally enjoying the action of a maritime battle. The wind, previously idle and aloof, picked up speed and leapt past my eardrums, bringing with them loud bursts of low rumbles. The wind never whistles, it screams.

"Ready! Aim! Fire!" The General's booming voice pierced the assailing current of air and the sound of a cannon firing pierced it right after. I felt a shockwave fly through my body and the water in front erupted in a bright flash, but the submarine underneath kept its pace.

"Ready! Aim! Fire!" The boy I loved sat at the artillery, his face a wash of concentration instead of the far-awayedness before when I knew he was thinking of me. The shot fired pushed him back rapidly as the round ripped through the dead air and hit the

attackers head on. I caught one last glance at him as I sprinted down to the orlop deck to find where we had been hit.

“They’re sinking! Brace for another shot!” The ship lurched again and sent me flying down the stairs and into the puddle of water forming at the bottom of our vessel. Water was leaking in *fast* . I grabbed the special watertight patches and waded over to the two holes in the hull, battling the immense force of an ocean deeper than my wildest nightmares. I heard shots being fired, smaller ones, from above me but I didn’t question their targets. I was focused on keeping our ship not on fire and not under water. The water stopped flowing in as I applied the second patch, and I slumped over, exhausted and injured. The cool water around my head, as well as the bobbing up and down that I felt in the sloshing mess lulled me back into the dreamland, but I was steadfast. Each beat of my heart lined up with the movement of the surrounding world, eating away at my composure. I felt like crying, but I could not bring myself to a reason for it. I had not lost anything, I had not lost myself, however I felt as if a part of me was bleeding out into the murkiness. My feet found the floor and my arms pushed upwards but my mind stayed in the water, moving about with my heart, growing ever louder. I had to be strong though. I could not afford to be the weak link on this mission.

As I rise back to the top of the ship, I see two floating dots behind us. The General is mounting the rifle back up on the shelf, clicking it into place, while his son scribbles in his journal. When I looked briefly, the only words I saw were *unidentified* and *unimportant*. Now past him, on a wooden bench, I lie down and finally rest my legs. They’re dull and motionless, but very much in pain from the encounter with the stairs and the metal floor below. I close my eyes for a moment and I’m gone, once again staring down that open rectangle into the deck below, full of dark black water. The tail of the great giant below us snaked through it, forming a large loop. Something floated up from the bottom, but there was not enough light to see what it is. The last thing that enters my mind is a blanket that I can only assume the General's son draped over my cold, wet body. And so I sleep at last.

Counting Landmines

It was one year before everything changed, but I was on the top of the world. I was about to be a teenager, the status that Aislin boasted ruthlessly to me, and that meant everything even if nothing specific would change. It was the difference between baby Finn and the badass that I had envisioned myself as. When we are children we don't have the capacity to understand just how small we actually are because a world larger than us has not become apparent. Those two children, one thirteen and one not, one me and one her, were both traipsing across a field of broken glass and landmines, but they could not see past the tops of their own noses. But they were together in this mad dance across death, their hands interlocked in the strongest of connections, a friendship above family. For them, family meant next to nothing, as to be expected of those born to powerful figures and queens. I don't blame my mothers for not knowing how to treat me as a child, since I've heard stories about what happened to them. The Horde, a force I had never encountered, was no parent. Aislin told me about how her grandmother died before we were born and that her mom's dad was missing for most of her life. Aislin's dad's dads were great, though, and Bow seemed to be the only competent parent in the whole palace. Parents and children are not so different, and it becomes easier to see that when they don't know what they're doing. While the two children danced around the minefield, their parents dove ahead of them to test the ground they walked over.

It was a mother's duty to take a blast to save their child, and they took many. But that fickle attempt to keep us unharmed failed because they had all been injured by the same blasts years before we had opened our tiny eyes. My Mama Catra had had enough pain before me and was never a good minesweeper. She often fell clumsily onto me and I still remember what happened when she did. I remember her snapping a lot, and when she did her eyes became filled with the power of the sun and mine became filled with tears. She never meant to hurt me but she always ended up

doing just that because she was the way she was and now I am the way I am. Perhaps it was good that she left.

One year before she left I was on top of the world. I was about to be a teenager. The wintertime was draining the color from the land outside the window, but not from the cheeks of two children. Aislin's color came in the form of music, and she sang a lot of it to me. At the back of the library was an ancient first one's instrument that consisted of various plates that Aislin would slap and they would sing alongside her voice. She was unconfident at first, writing short pieces that only had her touching the instrument in supple, barely noticeable ways. Her songs had few words and she said that she was bad at writing lyrics down. She would just wail out like a soft banshee, the ghosts leaving her mouth reaching my ears and doing something I was not familiar with. She was a talent, that much was apparent.

"Finn?" she asked me one day, almost completely out of the blue. "Can you draw me something?"

I asked her what she wanted, but she only told me to draw something I thought was pretty. I took a piece of paper and drew an odd flower, similar to the glowing ones in our garden that I would always hold delicately in my hand. I would pick them out of the ground and watch as their light slowly drained out as they died. It was sadistic to another eye, but I saw it as an odd form of nature's kiss. Beauty unfolding in a way that was neither natural or unnatural. When I gave her the drawing she thanked me, said goodbye, and shut herself in her room. I questioned her motives at the time but she was a weird girl, it was not out of the ordinary for her to act aloof like that. It was in my best interest to just let her do what she wanted, because it was most likely going to be something beautiful.

The next day arrived and she still hadn't told me what she had done with my drawing. At first I didn't really remember or care, but it was only when she asked me for another that my intrigue spiked. She was being quite secretive in a way that she never had been with me before. We were the only two kids in the palace, so

there was no reason to keep information from each other. Our brains were practically sewn together with how similar we acted, how much of the same information we both knew, how much about the world we both never imagined. We were so similar that we even both died at the same instant. Of course, I kept on walking and breathing and talking for another fourteen years, if today *is* the day that I close my eyes for the last time, but the day that her heart stopped was the day that mine followed suit. I will have spent exactly the same amount of time on this plane with her as I have without, but I have not been alive for the latter half of it. Aislin and I were closer than conjoined twins, two little dancers all alone, and when she stepped on a landmine it blew us both up. Her mangled remains are stuck to my head even now as I grapple with my own life. I can't help but think of her.

A snowstorm struck Bright Moon six days before my birthday. It was a blizzard the likes of which we had never dealt with. Aislin asked me to draw something else for her, so I drew a tree sagging over under the weight of the frozen water sitting on it. It's cruel how that works, at least that's what I thought when I was drawing it. The very substance that all of those trees needed to survive was now killing them, freezing and splitting the old summer trees open or toppling them under its foot. The power of winter was not to be messed with, something that Aunt Frosta told me once, and now I knew what it meant. The sun, usually high in the sky, was barely visibly through the clouds and the forest was lit in a dim, muted gray. Rather than stare at those all day, I sat in the library, finishing the Pine Cone Book and reading up on all of the wonderful living creatures that no longer lived in my kingdom. The heating in the library was always better than the rest of the palace because it was smaller and the books were deemed fragile and valuable enough to try and keep safe. The quiet spot in the back was equipped with large purple cushions that sunk down far enough to completely cover me as I read. The outside world no longer mattered because I was just there, alone with my book, awaiting the day I turned from a child of twelve years to one of thirteen.

Five days before it happened it was still snowing. The strong winds and deadly temperatures had ceased, letting the sun shine a little brighter than before. The port down below us was completely white, ice and snow blocking out the views of fish that froze underneath. Small white orbs floated down like feathers, making no noise whatsoever. Winter was always interesting to me because of how dead it was. I would step outside and only see two colors, white and grey, and would sense no wind or sound of any kind. It's as if Mother Nature was resting, saving her energy for another time to make the forest breathe and the wind ripple surfaces of water that break the light from the shimmering sun into fragments that fly straight through my glowing moon-eyes. Aislin told me to draw her something else, by this time I had given up on asking why and started theorizing instead, and so I drew a picture of summer. I looked outside and imagined what it might look like in a few months, bringing me into better times. My eyes watered a little bit, flowing creek water making its way into them, but I kept on drawing. I gave Aislin the drawing, she slinked back into her room, and that was that. At this time, I thought she was going to cut them all up and stitch them together in some sort of collage, but I had no better guesses than that. I knew it must have been for my birthday, since that's all I could think about for the entire week. On my way back to my room, I was intercepted by Bow who looked happier than normal for the time.

"Finn, did you hear who's coming to visit early?" he asked with an incredibly noticeable grin on his face. "Double Trouble!" Those words alone made me perk up, suddenly less bored than before. They were my favorite of the numerous family friends from far off kingdoms. Most of the time when people could come to visit, it all seemed fake to me. Forced smiles, awkward hugs, older women telling me how much I've grown (even though that was sort of nice). Double Trouble seemed to be above the niceties of conventional conversation, or below it, as they would probably describe themself. They seemed to stay the exact same age every time I saw them, maybe because they were shapeshifting around to appear as such. I had once asked them if they could die and

they laughed, cackled, before reassuring me that you would have to be a god to cheat death.

"Or a devil..." they said as I was walking away to get more food. I had been thinking about that sentence since my previous birthday party, and how incredibly cool it made them sound. I knew I wanted to be as cool as D.T.

The Devil themself arrived four days before I turned thirteen, their immense fur coat emitting its thick crimson glow across the white backdrop, making them visible from up in my room even though they were thousands of feet below getting off their opulent looking skiff. My moms were down there too to greet them, but I did not see them with their gold and stark white pearls. They blended in perfectly. I began sketching the sight, albeit with a few abstractions, in preparation of Aislin's odd request. I used a special red ink to splatter right in the middle of the grey and white pencil marks, making it impossible to ignore on the page. It was my favorite drawing I had made yet, even if it was one of the simplest. A few minutes later I found myself in the grand hall, embracing one of my best friends. They picked me up and spun me around with a strength I was surprised of, given my size and their skinny looking arms. If I was not Finn, the Moon of She-Ra, I would have been fearful for my own life.

"May I borrow them for the day?" they asked my parents in an overly exaggerated politeness. They were funny, even willing to mock the most powerful women in the universe as a joke. "I swear that this time I won't teach them how to throw knives again, that was a *one time* thing, wasn't it?" They turned and looked at me and I burst out laughing. Mama Adora reluctantly let me go as Mama Catra put her arm around her waist comfortingly. Mothers sometimes have to let their children walk alone through the minefield, even if it pains their hearts to watch them unprotected. A life bound to pillows and duct tape is not a meaningful one. Aislin's story was proof enough of that, as she would take every single opportunity possible to disobey her loving parents. She didn't even feel remorseful while doing it, and I never blamed her. She was just a child after all.

Double Trouble drove their skiff like a monster, racing around corners without braking and accelerating whenever possible. Trees made loud whooshes as they shrunk behind me into the viscerally shaking horizon. The lack of color blended together into one sludge that was penetrated again by the bright red fur coat. I asked where we were going, but they just smiled and giggled menacingly. I did mention they were my favorite, did I not? When we reached our destination the vehicle stopped almost completely out of the blue, the only thing preventing me from catapulting off into the snow being the bright red fur arms that made wintertime a little less boring. In front of us was a small cliff, jagged and square as if it was one part of a staircase large enough for gods to walk on. And so the bright red god that was holding me jumped off the skiff and onto the cold ice underneath. My legs were weak from holding on for my dear life, but I managed to drop down next to them and stare in awe at the painting right in front of me. The cliff's face was not occupied by stones and exposed soil, but by a large metal slab the size of two houses stacked on top of each other. I craned my neck upright to see to the top, only to be met with the blinding glare of the day-moon, the source of the grey wash that covered the world during this time of year. It was impossible to ignore.

"Follow me darling, there's another way in that isn't blocked by a broken door," they said, waving me over to the side, away from the door. Embedded in a rock was an inexplicably perfect square embossed into the natural surface. One press down and a sickening screech was bellowed from inside the cliff next to us. A boulder circled around, swiveled by an unseen motor, and opened up a path inside whatever the large metal door contained. As the bright red fur coat turned black, I had to rely solely on the sound of boots crunching small rocks on the cold floor we were treading on. The walls around us seemingly became tighter together for the longer we walked. We were in them for less than a minute but by the end I was ready to curl up in a ball and cry. But then the walls disappeared and I collapsed forward into the back of a fur coat shrouded in black. "Careful, you don't want to get us killed do you?" the coat said with a laugh. Of course I didn't.

Three days before my birthday I was sitting in a bathtub, soaking in the steam and the water that wasn't frozen under a layer of snow. My head was splitting in half, a sensation I was new to at the time, and I was taking a break from all social interactions. The events of the day before swirled around like the soap bubbles around my feet, although they never popped. Such an experience was something I never wanted to relive, however I was in no way regretful of what happened. A rush of pure adrenaline is terrifying in the moment, but it's a feeling unlike any other. A feeling that I would get my fair share of over the next thirteen years, but never like the fourth day. I did say that Double Trouble was my favorite, did I not?

As I soaked up the warmth, I heard a knock on the bath door behind me. I was ready to shout at whoever it was to get out, but then a familiar voice called out.

"Finn, have you finished the drawing yet?" echoed from behind the marble entryway, shoving the reminder in my face like a wall. I had completely forgot about the mysterious whatever that Aislin was working on.

"Yeah I can draw one but can you bring me my stuff? I don't want to get out of the tub."

"Alright, I'll be right back!" she called as her footsteps grew quieter, sprint off towards my room. A few minutes later I heard them return at a slightly slower pace, but much heavier than before. The box she had had to lug down a flight of stairs was filled with various art supplies including pigments, brushes, paper, pencils, and an open window towards anything I wanted. "I've got the box here, whatd'ya need?" she asked casually, her voice in less of a hurry than her feet were a few moments before.

"I don't know, just bring it in here so I can paint. I'll just lean out of the water for a second while I draw it for you." She opened the door behind me and I opened my eyes, turning my back to an odd enough angle to use the countertop beside me to draw. She set the box down next to me and took a seat for herself right outside

the entrance to the sauna. I unlocked the intricate brass on the front of the case to reveal the full extent of my imagination lying right in front of me. Using a towel to quickly wipe off my hands, I carefully took a thicker sheet of paper and held it underneath my head. The water dripped down onto the white surface and joined together in a small pool. Aislin watched me closely, an unreadable expression chiseled on her face. I clicked open the case of pigments taking out the containers filled with red, yellow, and black powder. Dipping my brush in the soapy bath water, I took a pinch of the red pigment and sloshed the wet fibers around in it. Aislin shifted her stance in the chair, her face still unmoving. With a hand steadier than a surgeon I dragged the red brush through the air and forced it down onto the paper. An explosion of blood streaked outwards from a point just left of the center of the paper, coating it in clouds of fog. A small gust of air flew past Aislin's mouth and into my ears a few feet away, queuing me into the fact that she had never seen me use such a technique. I had never tried it before, but in the moment it just felt like an interesting thing to do. I took barely any black powder, the substance as thick as death, and repeated the same process as with the red. I shook the paper, the water flying all round on it and making an odd pattern of blotches and pseudopods on the page. The painting was converted into a nighttime dance between a blood moon, the blackness of space, and a moving river. I still left some bits of white underneath to make the black less lonely in its place. You can never have darkness without its eccentric wife, light, or so I was told by Gardener many years before. The last thing I did to the poor piece of paper was add the finishing touches. A night scene is never finished without fireflies. I took small bunches of the yellow pigment in my fingers and threw it against the scene. Instantly life was breathed into it all, and I was satisfied at last. "Here, do you like it?" I asked while leaning over to hand her the finished product.

"It's beautiful, Finn," she said with the same stone-carved expression she had held for the past hour. Her eyes brightened alongside the colors in the picture, and then she turned and left. She closed the door with the silence and effortlessness of a fairy

and walked back to her room, her feet now invisible to my ears. Taken aback by the ghostly occurrence I had witnessed, I slid back into the soapy, warm water of the bathtub and let the water slosh around the side of my head like fingers.

Two days before my birthday I was too tired to get out of bed. My legs were weaker than before but my mind was racing once more. Inevitably feeling a little bad for the mildly traumatic event they caused me, Double Trouble came into my room and brought a deck of playing cards. Their cards had apparently been enchanted by a magician out in the middle of the woods and act differently when playing different games. I watched intently as the pictures got up as we were playing War and tore the other ones to shreds. Truly a remarkable game. As the bright red demon got up to leave, they left the cards and winked.

"Sorry about the other day, Darling. I promise to make up for it with my gift this year." They always managed to sound cool even when admitting defeat.

My drawing for Aislin that day took me more time than every other one I had made. I took the largest piece of paper in the collection, every colored pencil I owned, and started working my way through each one of them. I must have owned at least one hundred different shades and hues, but I kept working. Aislin came a checked in on it every so often, sometimes staying and watching for a few minutes, sitting beside me on the bed. Her eyes told me she was still there, but her face could have fooled anyone of the opposite. Still to my dying breath I'm wondering what she was going through at the time. I was dismissive of the oddity at the time but it only grew stranger each day I remembered it. Once my cavalcade of colors was finished, she fell back into the white inverted shadows that filled the empty spaces between walls in the palace. She was silent as a ghost.

One day before my thirteenth year alive was complete my legs decided to work once more. I was vibrating with energy, ready to spend it all in excitement for the day that would follow. Unfortunately, Double Trouble was nowhere to be found and Aislin

was being herself. All I could do that day was think, read, and draw. And so I did just that. Aislin's drawing was my top priority and I let her know that before locking myself away in the library to look for ideas. I settled on painting a lotus flower, an exotic creature that I had never seen for myself. It was said to grow in even the dirtiest, murkiest waters, making any environment more lively than before. Hours later, when I was done, I presented it to the curious goddess that was always watching me and she seemed pleased. Once more she floated back to her room and shut the door. I watched her disappear and thought very little about it before going downstairs to the kitchen to find food to eat.

Twenty-four hours later, the day of my birth, Aislin was already dead.

This Puny World pt. 2

Sailing with the Salenias Royal Navy was one of the best and worst decisions of my life simultaneously. By the time I had turned eighteen, life alone in Bright Moon Palace was becoming more and more depressing, to the point of almost breaking down. I had no friends, barely any present family, little entertainment aside from drawing or painting, and a lifetime's worth of traumatic memories to sift through. Mom hated the idea of me going off to help ward off the new threat of pirates out at sea, but I told her I would at least get to live again. She seemed to understand in some capacity because she shot me a pensive look, as if saying sorry for all of the life I had lost in my time alive.

I met the Fleet Admiral, my uncle Sea Hawk, at our port in the early days of spring and he welcomed me in with an... interesting performance. I thought he was quite funny but in a way that made me embarrassed for him. His constant twirls of the mustache or puffing of the chest and biceps were unfit for a man of his age, but his energy rivaled that of even my own. His deep blue suit was unbuttoned, leaving it waving frantically in the strong winds that occupied our home this time of year. His body danced with the ripples in the water below and I could immediately see why he was the highest up in the Navy, apart from being Mermista's husband. He practically *was* the ocean herself. However, as we sailed away from home and I stared up at the opulent castle behind us, he noticed me and was aware of the turmoil I was going through. It's always the ones that seem like idiots that are smart enough to not need to act like it all the time. He was comforting throughout the whole week journey over to the port city of Phobos, a quality that I surely needed.

As we were floating out, far away enough from land for it to fade from view, I was sitting by the edge of the railing. My feet dangled precariously over the edge of the boat, most likely only kept up by my balance. The sun was uncontested in the sky, warming me against the cool breeze that filled my eardrums with Mother Nature's humming. As my eyes were locked below me on

the water, I noticed something that sent a shiver down my spine. Directly underneath us was a faint outline, incredibly difficult to spot had it not been for the sunlight, of a giant serpent. I could not tell where its head or tail was, as all I could see was a body larger than a mountain. It pulsed slightly as it breathed, large gulps traveling clumsily down the length of its godlike structure. I thought I was imagining it, not the first time I had hallucinated, but the image was already burned into my mind. I never asked Sea Hawk about what I saw, but I learned later from his brother that it was indeed real, and it was indeed peaceful. Something so much bigger than us is bound to not care at all what we do, since nothing could possibly lay a finger to the power that it must possess. Looking at it, I was reminded of how small I was. How small I am.

When we got to the city, it was bubbling with people, places, and things, overwhelming my every sense. The taste of salt in the air reminded me of how far I was from home. The sight of a metropolis sprawling across the coastline like ink on a wet canvas was inspiring, one I had not seen before even when I visited the royal palace for gatherings. The smell of smoke, fish, and a cacophony of many other unrecognizable scents filled my nose with visions of countless types of everyday lives from working in a factory to sitting by the beach, sipping tea. The feeling of cool wind ruffled my hair and sent goosebumps down my body, now more lifelike than ever. The combined sound of feet scuffling against the docks, voices murmuring to create a low drone, children scampering around like squealing pigs, and the undying breath of Mother Nature's stomach became a slurry of airwaves that made no sense as I listened. And yet it made all the sense in the world.

I stayed in Phobos for only three days as I was prepared for my time in service. I was not looking forward to it, but I pushed on anyways simply because looking back had been erased as an option by this point. While I was there, I made a few little-while friends, including an alley cat that the locals simply called "Jay", a kindly old street vendor who had skin that was tinted an odd shade of magenta, and some boys that were playing with a ball in

a small court. I would play with them when I could, holding my own nicely in dodgeball. I was not the most physically fit or athletic, but my time walking and hiking as well as my ripe age made me agile enough that they liked having me around. I almost had time to find one of the boys there pretty cute, but in doing so I forgot that I had very little time there. He had lovely, deep brown eyes and a face that was neither childlike nor mature. He was always on the other team but I didn't mind getting to look at him. Three days later, I was whisked off on a large battleship with the rest of my group, and I never saw the boy or the rest of my friends ever again. Well except for one, but even now I'm not sure if I imagined it or not.

The uniforms provided to me and the rest of the recruits were anything but comfortable. Draped in a similar, albeit lighter, shade of blue as the Lieutenant General's suit, we were immediately reminded of our lesser positions by the dirty work we had to do around the ship. It was a massive vehicle, one meant to shoot and kill others, but we only saw the rough intestines and organs that filled its giant metal hull. The engines, two massive turbines in the back, were loud and constantly in need of maintenance. Every once in a while we would have to clean the inactive one, as only one of them ran at a time to conserve energy, and such a task required four people who all would brave the humongous globs of grease and rust that the machine had caked on. The smell was putrid, numbing my nostrils to anything else that may have felt nice, and my eyes were constantly tearing up. That was one of the most common tasks, although we were not unaware of more normal tasks like scrubbing floors or cleaning weapons. As difficult as the early weeks were, I still preferred it over having to live in isolation back home, no friends, no fears, nothing. And I hadn't even faced combat yet, a job that was only meant for higher ranking soldiers. I was not a high ranking soldier.

One thing that particularly appealed to me in this large group was that I was completely unknown. Everyone there was a commoner, a peasant, or arrogant. No one in any royal family would be stupid enough to send their heirs off in battle, much less *the* She-Ra, but

I guess I was a special case. No one there had ever set foot in Bright Moon Palace, a policy that the Queen upheld that I found quite stupid. It was such a big space, but there were no large parties or feasts or events held besides coronations or funerals. None of these people were at Aislin's funeral, because if they were I would have remembered. My cover story for when people asked me who I was needed some work, but I initially just told them that I was an orphan who lived in the small town of Elberon out in the woods. While I thought of some additions to that story, no one really asked me or seemed to care at all. I loved it there.

By the time the first month had passed, my group of friends had grown immense and diverse. I had a small inner group of three friends (although I was on good terms with almost everyone), my bunkmate and the two people from the one next to us. My bunkmate, a girl from the Kingdom of Snows, was named Teplo after the ancient word for "warmth", a description I thought was fitting for such a comforting friend. She would crack jokes, give us hugs, tell us ghost stories, and listened to all of my poems. During the nighttime, she would usually be the quietest but you could tell she would always be listening because the next day and days after she could remember exactly what you told her. On the bottom bunk next to us was Saua, a Salenias boy who's name did not match his description like Teplo's did. Meaning "ferocious", he was really anything but. I still have a hard time imagining him ever going into battle, much less killing somebody larger than a gnat. Then dust. He was a little less conversationally aware than Teplo was, constantly jutting in with his own remarks and reactions, but they were never out of malice or provocation. He was not large, but not small, and most likely could easily bench press me in a second if he wanted to. We actually joked about that with him and he just shrugged and said "probably, I don't know," and then moved on. He was simply the best moral support around the whole navy. The top bunk above him was occupied by a kid with a stupid name, Hamm. I forgot if it meant something or if he was just messing with us by telling everyone he was Ham-with-two-ems. He was constantly cracking jokes, livening up the more tense talks we had. Sometimes he didn't know when to turn

on his filter but he was so funny that no one even cared. When I told him that my mom had left me when I was thirteen, all he had to say was "damn, sounds like a *her* problem but go on" and I couldn't help but laugh. Maybe we've spent too long being scared of our past memories and it's time to look at them in the face and laugh.

So that's exactly what I plan on doing.

Around three years ago, after having been in the navy for over five years, I became acquainted with the Lieutenant General. It was completely accidental, as acquaintances often are, but it was at the perfect time for my best interest and perfect circumstance. The war we were fighting while I was there was one against pirates, or at least that's what we were supposed to call them. Their ships all held the same insignia, a coiled sea serpent, and operated in an organized fashion. They were similar to ours but smaller, easier to destroy, and *much* faster. They were unlike any pirates I had ever seen, down to their matching uniforms. It was an army. While deep into the Great Ocean, our ship and her fleet encountered a new threat: submarines. Their underwater boats were at first invisible, but when daybreak came and we were all halfway to drowning, the sharks bore their fangs underneath the surface.

That night was one of the most terrifying occurrences of my life, a brush with death closer than even the night that I died for the first time. It was a peaceful day before it all, bright sun and calm waves. The engines weren't running on high and we were awaiting orders from higher officers. Teplo, Saua, and a new friend of ours we called Nana (because his name was too hard to pronounce) had joined me in a game of four-way-chess, a new pastime we invented involving four chess boards and a massive amount of chaos. Ham-with-two-ems had drowned two years prior. The kitchen had made the most edible food yet, spaghetti, and we were all stuffed full of it. Teplo rested her head on my legs after she had lost, ruining my concentration while still trying to beat the other two, who had ganged up on me because I was

better than them at chess. I had been dating her for a while now, an odd relationship that wasn't purely functional, but we were affectionate nonetheless. A few newer recruits caught us having sex in a bathroom once, but since we were in charge of them they knew they couldn't say anything about it. Having some sense of control felt good, even if I was still pretty low in the pecking order still. It was a long climb to the top.

It was a vicious attack, a barrage of torpedoes that was most likely excessive in its power. I stopped counting after we were hit by ten, but it went on for quite a bit longer. In our cabin, higher up on the boat, the four of us had more time to escape than others did, but it was a manic scramble at best. We felt the listing almost immediately, the boat teetering over to its port side before falling over completely and sinking. It took around thirty minutes to go down, and in that time I amassed a burden I haven't let go even now. We tore down the corridor, out to the decks, and started for the lifeboats before we were stopped. Before I was stopped.

"Guys! Wait!" It was Saua, he looked as if he was crying. "My dad's back there, we have to make sure he's okay!" he said while breathing heavily, the water from his mouth turning into a visible cloud in front of him. I looked at him, then at the other two. We were all standing as still as statues.

"Okay," I began reluctantly. "I will go with Saua while you two get to a lifeboat. We shouldn't all have to go, we'll just clog up the corridors." I looked at Teplo in the eyes, begging her to comply and not make the parting a difficult one. She seemed to understand, because she kissed me on the cheek, grabbed Nana, and ran for her life. Saua and I ran in the opposite direction, darting around towards the back of the ship. I didn't know that Saua's dad was even on the ship, but he would never lie to us so I guess he just never cared to bring it up. The blaring alarms and the voices small and large all flew past me as I flew past them, the ship slowly turning over on its side.

As we rounded the top of a staircase, we spotted the Lieutenant General himself. I could see the fear in his eyes as he struggled to lift a large metal support beam off of his leg. It looked as if he had gotten himself free, but even from far away I could tell it was broken. Saua immediately rushed in to get him up and I followed closely behind him. As we reached him, I could see that what I had thought to be fear in his eyes was actually anger, I was unsure of what it was directed to. Hoisting him up, Saua and I tried to talk to him, but his skin was turning white and his leg was dripping a deep red, visible even in the floodlights of the same color. We had to get him off of the ship before he bled out. I looked to my friend as we moved methodically back down the stairs, to see if I could tell what he was thinking. I finally pieced together that his father was the man I was carrying, simply by the way he looked at him.

As we neared the bottom of the stairs I started to panic more. The ship was tilting more and more, and we were running out of time. I heard shots ringing out through the hollow walls, screaming coming directly after. *They've boarded the ship.* I mouthed the words to Saua, who understood and started ducking down, becoming lighter on his feet and quieter with his breath. He was holding his father's arms, and I his legs. I was moving backwards while he was facing behind me, where we needed to go. There was one floor left to clear before we were in the last stretch of hallway, but footsteps outside halted our progression.

"I'll check over there, you get the stairs." The command was sickening to my stomach, but I stayed quiet as I reached for my pistol. I carefully laid the General on the ground, out of sight, as I turned around and got ready to fire. The footsteps thudded against the steel, each one louder than the last. No sounds could be heard except for the distant alarms and the cries of a sinking ship. Underneath my feet I heard quiet screaming, soldiers trapped in rising waters. I looked down briefly, instinctively, as I thought of whether I had time to try and save them. They were going to drown in a matter of minutes if I didn't do something. That's when it happened.

"Finn look out!" I heard Saua scream. Two shots exploded as I ducked my head to the ground. As I looked up, I aimed my pistol and fired, the pirate directly in its path shuddering and collapsing to the ground, a hole in their face. I heard a thud behind me but I did not have time to turn around because the blood rushing to my ears brought my awareness up higher than usual. There were more soldiers coming, and I had to survive to help Saua bring his father to safety.

He was counting on me.

Ugly Faces

Back before we knew better, Aislin and I would gossip all the time and make fun of whoever we wanted. We would call our parents names, make up stories about the guards behind their backs, and had fun doing it too. We would do it to our tutor, the poor man, and soon enough we had a version of him in our minds that was most likely further from the truth than we were from self-awareness. According to us he had three children, all of which were "stupid", as we called them, and one of them would wet the bed every night. The tutor's spouse had an ugly face just like him, which is the only reason they married each other. There were many more, far smaller details that we invented but to recount them would cause me great emotional pain. I may be dying, but I'm not quite that desperate yet.

One unfortunate victim of our storytelling was the son of the Queens of the Crimson Waste, Dionaea. He had flowers in his hair, but a rough exoskeleton, just the kind of anomaly that confused us enough to poke fun at him. During one particular summer season, his family came to visit for two weeks. Initially we were ecstatic that we would finally get to meet a child of the Waste, the tough-as-nails criminal haven, so our daydreams of him being a macho tough guy (at the age of seven) would eventually lead to disappointment. It was our first time meeting Aunts Scorpia and Perfuma since we were both infants, so essentially it was our first time ever setting our eyes on them. They were kind to us from the start, something that we did not trust until they revealed large presents from their bag.

Unfortunately, their child did not receive the same trust. I do not remember his true name, the one his parents assigned him, but the one that Aislin and I decided on for ourselves was “Chunky”. We were cruel children. Chunky, due to his slight bulge at the stomach, was subject to many smug remarks and insults, some blunt some hidden, about his weight and stature. Aislin would lead the charge and I would follow, usually resulting in him scoffing and looking hurt, but never doing anything about it.

Once, after calling him a “little piglet” (her idea), we became increasingly confused as to why he was not retaliating or at least telling his mothers.

“Mommy says that if people say mean things to me it’s because they’re sad, so I shouldn’t feel bad for myself, I should feel bad for them!”

Well, that made absolutely no sense to two children who thought they were happier than anyone on the planet simply because they had each other. We started making even more fun of him after that, the beratings occurring more frequently and with more venom. We started testing the waters, seeing how far we could go before he eventually snapped.

“Everyone has their limit, that’s what mommy told me”. Aislin was, for some reason, hellbent on finding it. I, for some reason, was hellbent on doing whatever she did. Chunky was only over for two weeks, but it would be the only time he would ever spend at the palace as long as I have lived.

After a few days, the torture became physical. While the adults were off talking about whatever it is adults talk about when children are absent, they would send us to go outside and play. By nighttime, the castle guard would come fetch us and bring us in for dinner, usually a delicious meal that Chunky would devour faster and more efficiently than everyone but his mother Scorpia. This was ammunition for two twisted minds.

One day, we went to the kitchen and asked the staff to bake us a small cupcake. We told them we wanted to gift it to our dear friend from the Crimson Waste, who was leaving in seven days. The baker was happy to oblige, and in an hour or two we had our divine disguise. Aislin, the day before, had picked up a worm from the forest floor and smiled maniacally. I asked her why she was smiling but she only put a finger on her lips and mouthed the words *Lay Ter* . Well, later had come and I finally understood. We found Chunky in the garden, his legs spread out in the procured lawn, his eyes wandering around the bees that dotted the colorful

walls of flowers. We put on our best faces, best walks, and best postures and we held out the cupcake on a silver platter. He looked up at us and smiled.

"We're really sorry, honestly. We've been so mean to you but we don't mean any of it."

"Yeah, we just didn't know you well enough, but you're not actually a loser, I was joking."

We could have won awards for our act. Even our parents would probably be fooled, maybe not Mama Catra, into thinking we had come to our senses. But our senses were long since gone, and the cupcake was fit with a nice surprise.

As he smiled, thanked us, and took the cupcake, our faces revealed nothing. Even as he took his first small bite off of the top, we just sat down with him and waited. He licked off the icing from his fingers and then from the top of the treat, and we made small talk, asking him about his life back home. We didn't care about his life back home. And finally, he took a gigantic gulp right through the middle of the cupcake. For a few seconds, each one lasting an eternity, his lips moved methodically and his teeth smushed the desert into a paste. His eyes were unchanging, only displaying a mild sense of happiness and calm, unsuspecting of the oncoming torture, this worm only serving as a starting pistol to a whole week of our best efforts. And then, after we had all grown old and died, he tasted it. The mess of brown fudge and icing erupted outward, past his stomach and then his esophagus and then his mouth and onto the pristinely-kept grass of the Bright Moon gardens. His moon-eyes turned into suns and, if only for a moment, we saw true fury behind those shallow reflecting pools. A fire burned impossibly bright, but then was exhausted by the prevalent feeling of disgust and pain as he wretched again.

Initially, I was disturbed by the pitiful sight, but my friend began laughing as her brilliant scheme came to fruition. It truly was a contagious laugh, if you heard it you would assume she had just

heard a hilarious joke, and was bellowing without malice. If there was one substance that she had in abundance, it was malice.

After someone close to you dies, they undergo a metamorphasis. There is always an immediate image of someone that appears as you first meet them. After a while, their living body is transferred to your mind, assuming you get to know who they really are. While they are beside you, you assume that this is who they are, because you're breathing and talking and living with them. Then they die, and the metamorphasis begins. An afterimage, a hazy, smudged, beautiful painting with large brush strokes and bright colors, is so hard to observe because it ignores half of what made the person a person. When they die, it is hard to think negatively of them, because you cannot bear to believe that some things are better off now that they are gone. You are not better off now that they are gone. All of the amazing, alright, and moderately mediocre things they did indent the print that stays right inside of you, under the surface of a shallow lake, for days, months, years, or forever. Depending on who you are, this may be the last you see of this loved one. I didn't give it much thought until I lost another friend of mine to a bullet right in his head. I thought long and hard about everything he had done, all of the people he had to be for me in order to keep both of us sane, and I realized something important. There is another, final image that a person transforms into far after they are gone from the face of reality. An after-after image leaves behind everything that was so beautiful about the first print and all that remains is the filth. The moss, mold, and barnacles under the belly of the beast that was the beautiful person you thought you once knew. It's shocking at first, but you stop feeling bad about yourself because the person is dead. Aislin died and brought me along with her, and that is not what a good friend would do. If she had been a good friend, I would not be here, I would still be able to think kindly of her. But she was not kind, she was not good, and she was not beautiful. Her ugly face, along with her ugly laugh, her ugly corpse, her ugly intentions, and her ugly parents were nothing but the scum of the world, the damned souls that we were warned of as kid. Little Devils.

If I had never met Aislin, I would not be lying down, unconscious, waiting to lose the rest of my blood.

Snakes

Whether faced or faceless, my fear had grown an immeasurable amount from the time of the attack. The man that I thought was Saua's father, the man that we were trying to rescue, was not even remotely related to him. I learned this after they both died. The man that I held on my back as I raced through the ship and out to sea, finally finding my way to a lifeboat, was the Lieutenant General, and a very important man. Saua chose to try and save him in the sinking rather than look around for where his father might be. We never found his father's body, but Saua himself laid there on that staircase, miles below the surface of the sea.

After we got to the shore safely, most everyone still intact and alive, I was given a letter with an important looking seal on it. The person who gave it to me had an unreadable look on their face, and I could not decide whether it was jealousy, admiration, or indifference. After tearing it open sloppily (I didn't own a letter opener) I took out the crisp paper and noticed immediately how fancy it appeared. The page was of a fine texture that I had never felt on a piece of paper before that moment, and the handwriting was bordering on becoming an art. It was so pompous and excited that I could barely even read the words that it was so dying to spit at my face. The envelope itself was a light shade of lilac, a color I saw often but never like I did then. It was always on flowers, or in the light of a magical spell or animal, never on a formal envelope. Taking all of this in, I already knew who it was from.

Addressed to the distinguished Officer Finn, of the Salineas Royal Navy,

May this message find you in good spirits and health, as you deserve to be following an event such as the boarding, and subsequent sinking, of a prime vessel. (He had humor at least). *It has come to my attention that you are the child of She-Ra, raised in the home of Bright Moon under King Bow and the late Queen Glimmer. It does not surprise me that such a courageous boy was*

made of you. (Ouch, he called me a boy). *After all that you did to save my life, I truly and sincerely owe you everything, although I cannot give everything to you and you would never accept it if I tried. Instead, this letter will serve as a formal invitation to a dinner with me and my family, in my estate, two days from now. There is an escort planned and you do not have to worry about fancy dress or manners, as I'm sure you have had enough of those in your royal lifestyle.*

Eagerly awaiting your visit,

Lieutenant General Serpentine of the Salineas Royal Navy

Looking back on it now, where I sit awaiting the waves to wash over me forever, Serpentine was quite a funny name for him to have.

"Welcome, Finn, I hope your trip up here was alright?"

"Well, I was too busy not paying any attention to notice."

"Ah- yes, well I suppose that's normal for a man of your age-"

"Well, I'm suddenly quite hungry, sir. Let's eat."

Our greeting was awkward in every way imaginable. I could tell that he wanted to accommodate me and thank me for saving his life, but I knew it was simply a common courtesy. I had heard a story from one fellow officer who swam down nearly fifty feet to save a commander from drowning, and never shook away the memory. Apparently, that commander invited them over to stay at their house for dinner and they did not get along. No names were told to me, but the officer was incredibly condescending and insulted the nation state which my friend had come from. I knew what to expect, and I wanted it to be clear that I was not a fan of the system established for us. In hindsight, I wish I had been a little bit more friendly to him, but it was something else that would eventually bring us together again.

"Well, I hope you can make yourself at home here," said the man who was also a Serpent, clearly knowing that there was no way I would feel at home in his mansion. "The dining hall is right through here, I'm terribly sorry for the long walk."

"Oh, I used to walk miles back home to Bright Moon for dinner, this is nothing."

"Ah, so you were an adventurous one?"

"I beg your pardon?" I had heard my mom use that expression once, and it brought me some relief to not be on the receiving end of it.

"Well, you must have been walking through the whispering woods, away from the palace, I heard that those are quite dangerous for children."

"Oh no, I never left the grounds." He had tried to brag with his line about the long walk, I was only leveling the playing field. And besides, his grand mansion was nothing more than a glorified collection of rooms that just so happened to form a symmetrical pattern. The pure nothing on display everywhere was seemingly intentional, because most architects at least have minds and styles of their own. Not this one. No one plank of wood nor stone in the walls was placed in an interesting or unique way, or with any thought whatsoever. It was so uninteresting that I found myself fixated upon its uninterestingness, an almost intentional lack of everything. I felt trapped by these walls that I agreed to close myself off in, but they were not invasive or claustrophobic, simply tall and there. In Bright Moon, there were shapes and colors that would fit in place like a puzzle along the walls, large or oddly shaped windows that let through light in the day and nighttime, patterns and platforms and pores and paintings, veins, mouths, eyes, faces. This house was a block of stone and wood, each angle made somehow less substantial than the last. The windows faced a direction which did not let the beautiful light of sunset gleam through onto the walls or floors and filled no spaces other than the short sills that one could not find themselves sitting

in. I could not even bring myself to hate this house, for putting that much effort into forming an opinion would not be worth my time. One day I hoped that the war against the "pirates" would wipe away the coastlines with constant cannonballs firing in combat, or waves the size of mountains would come and seize the kingdom of Salineas, so that house would no longer be standing at the top of this cliff, overlooking the far more beautiful ocean and sky. I could not wait to leave that place so I could forget its every detail.

"I see you're an admirer of this house," said the Serpent who was a man.

"Yes, it's pretty."

He was gorgeous.

While the dinner was still being prepared, I had been sat down at the foot of the table, across the way from the General. It was not a pleasant spot to be in, seeing as there were more chairs in between us than could ever fit a normal family. Perhaps if every aunt and uncle and their children came, there would be a demand for more seats. We tried to make small talk, he asked me about myself and I lied, I asked him about the Navy and he spouted nonsense, it was not working. That is, however, until his son entered the room. Suddenly, I was quite interested in the conversation to be held.

I had never been the romantic type. I'm not sure if I had felt that way about Aislin, I probably would've eventually, but ever since that was cut short I resulted to short flings and partners that didn't mean much, including the one I had at the time. I never told her I was leaving or how I really felt, but I'm certain she figured out for herself, or maybe she only will once she hears of my fate. Sexual pleasure was always a temporary thing, never more than a high I would occasionally chase, and often times that got me into trouble with people who thought differently. My first year at the navy, some guy who fucked me tried coming up and

hugging me the day after, and I jumped around and punched him in the face, not knowing who it was or why they would ever do that. It took quite a while to get comfortable with Teplo, and that relationship was not purely functional anyways. Initially, all of this was going through my head as I first laid eyes on this beautiful boy. I was thinking of all the uses he could have, all the ways he would get mad at me once I left with no goodbye, but the thoughts would soon dissipate.

"Ah yes, he has finally arrived! Finn, meet my wonderful son, Serpienta."

"I'm sure our names won't confuse you."

The first words out of his mouth struck me as odd. Such a naturally appealing facade usually was backed by some deep, sultry voice, but he sounded like no one I had ever expected. It was bordering between nervous and uncaring, like he was trying his best to seem nonchalant but not quite hitting the mark. I looked at him and smiled, the way new guests often do, and he smiled back to me. My face only got brighter, which seemed to change his in a way that I could not interpret. But once the pleasantries were done away with, and the food was set and ready to eat, we began to talk. I had expected it to be polite conversation, mentioning the war and politics and my mom and random things about Queen Glimmer (which people asked me way too much). The drabness of the house, the Serpent, the lights, the food, the table, everything just screamed boring thoughts burrowing into my brain, but the new factor, that little streak of sunlight at the end of the day, made it bearable. I felt more comfortable to talk more openly, and everyone there seemed to notice. We talked about the Pirates, what we thought about different leaders and policies, art, childhood stories, their mother who had died, my mother who had left us, and the depths of hell and heaven themselves.

It was many hours before it was time for me to go, as staying at the house of someone like this was frowned upon after you were there overnight. The moon was making its way down by the time

the escort was called to bring me back to town, a small fishing village, where our boat was currently docked. Soon after, I was to be reassigned to a more direct position, and the front lines became my home. It would be ages before I spoke to the Snakes ever again, although Serpienta stayed in the back of my mind for the whole time, and I would never end up seeing my friends from the other unit ever. I heard once that Teplo had led the capture of a major military base of the Pirates, and that the casualty rate was heavy for the Navy, but nowhere near as high as the Pirates. While it would have filled me with pride before, all it did then was bring me to tears. I had never wanted any of the complications that inevitably came with having to live, and I could not find it in me to forget my friends, even if I was unsure about how I felt towards some of them. I remembered losing Saua to a gunshot, Catra to her past, Glimmer to herself, and Aislin, but I never knew that I would lose one of my closest partners to the very thing I myself wanted only months before. She survived the raid, and somehow that made things worse.

Nothing about the world I was living in was true.

What Happened in the Cave

"Careful, you don't want to get us killed do you?" the coat said with a laugh. Of course I didn't. The tight walls of the cave behind us seemed much smaller than should have been possible, but we both managed to fit through them. One shape-shifter, one small child. I timidly stepped around, feeling out with my hands, connecting with the cold metal railings that seemed to keep us safe from an immense drop. Every sound we made reverberated back into our ears, giving away the true scale of the room.

"I can't see anything, is there a light in here?"

"Ah yes, I forgot you couldn't see in the dark," they said with an audible grin. As if on cue, I heard the sound of a switch being flipped and one by one the lights blinked on. As I rubbed my eyes, they slowly adjusted to the sudden blast, and then did a double take. The room was not a room, not a cave, but a facility. Large tanks and skiffs lined the floor, large support columns creating repetitive patterns as far down as my eyes could bear to look. Racks with weapons and small black packs were interspersed across the seabed of pure destructive power, making it seem like some sort of invasion that never took place. The only thing missing were the soldiers. With no life breathed upon the weapons, I could only see the place as a tomb.

"It's... huge." My voice trailed off, not in disappointment, but in the sheer number of thoughts going through my head at that moment. I thought about what this arsenal could have accomplished, why it was here, and how it was mere miles from my home. It was around this time I truly realized the horrific nature of war, a fact that seems obvious to me now. As destructive as the war was before I was born, the one I was going to face in less than a decade was to be far worse. The stockpile of tanks, guns, bombs, and weapons seemed like overkill, but it was a mere drop in the bucket to what both sides of the battle held, back then *and* now.

Double Trouble cast a bittersweet grin, looking at me only out the side of one eye. They seemed to be edging me to follow them, their feet already making their way over to the makeshift ladder. We both slowly inched our way down, feeling smaller than ants in this underworld. Each rung of the ladder consisted of an uneven piece of scrap metal, probably harvested from the weapons around the complex, and were rusty, damp, or both. My feet almost slipped many times but, not wanting to seem weak in front of Double Trouble, I kept on moving. The blisters started to form when I was almost all the way down, the stinging feeling implanting a terrifying thought into my head: how would I get back up? I tried to ignore it, pushing on and on and on, but the pain was increasing with every move I made. Right as I was about to slip and let myself fall out of exhaustion, my feet sensed a familiar feeling. Solid ground.

"Welcome to hell!" they shouted into the void, letting their voice echo across the walls and become powerful like a tidal wave of sound. Welcome to hell. For such an outlandish statement, it was actually quite accurate. Everywhere I looked I saw tools honed to kill. The tracks of tanks were taller than I was, taller than both of us, and there were hundreds of them. As I began walking towards Double Trouble, I saw something else. The first sense that caught the image was the scent, and it was a rotten image. The stoic figure in front of me seemed unbothered by the odor, but they noticed me holding my nose and looked worried. "Don't worry, nothing here can hurt you, I'm scarier than anything around." I smiled and embraced them, they were the comfort in this strange place. Fueled by their confidence, I scrunched up my nostrils and waded through the thick smell. I thought it was old food, or blast chemicals, or some animal that had died or shat on the ground or something, but the next sense would be much stronger, and much more terrifying. We kept walking, it seemed like a maze of giant vehicles, but Double Trouble seemed to know where they were going. Every so often they would send a few encouraging words back to me, reassuring me that what they wanted to show me was worth it, and that we were close. In the end, I'm glad I saw it, but it was not the only sight I remember about that day.

"We're close, I think it's through this little door here." There was a small station, probably quarters for a general or a room where all the strong soldiers talked around a map and planned where to destroy next. The door was rusted over, but the marvelous creature could open it with ease. "This way, I think," they told me, and so I stepped through the door as they held it open. The scent seemed to be getting stronger, but I ignored it mostly because I was good at ignoring things I didn't like. The ground underneath my feet made an odd noise, alerting my ears. My foot felt wet, I had just stepped in a puddle. The scent was unbearable in here. The air tasted foul, in fact, being able to taste the air was a sense I was not accustomed to. I heard the footsteps behind me stop, replaced instead by a gasp. My first instinct was to turn around, but my eyes finally caught the source of the scent from all around the complex. In every corner I had gone, in the tanks, under the blankets, behind the doors, I was smelling the unmistakable presence of decaying corpses. I looked down, the blood seeping into my socks a thicker red than the coat my auntie was wearing. My auntie who led me into the wrong room. The room filled with dead bodies.

"Finn, step back, this was not the right room."

"Auntie, these people are dead."

"Finn, yes they are. Just step out of the room, they can't hurt you."

I was silent.

"Finn, come to me, I'll bring you to the right room, don't worry about them."

I couldn't move.

"Finn! Get the fuck out of there!"

The loud noise shocked me back awake, and I backed out of the room as fast as I could. My foot slipped on something and I tumbled over. Double Trouble caught me before I fell, holding me

tight. I couldn't help but to look down and I saw a hand holding a pistol. I had slipped on a hand that had raised a gun to shoot its owner only years before that very day. My stomach began to rumble violently, and my auntie held me as I vomited out on the hard concrete beneath us. All of these soldiers had come to kill us, and all of them are dead. They still are now, and I can almost relate to that. Back then, death was a very new concept to me. We had just stepped into a tomb of thousands and, before that day, I had never seen a dead body in my life. I was about to become accustomed to the concept, that week being filled with losses, but what a terrible start it was. Double Trouble never forgave themselves for that day, and aside from one interaction just before my birthday, I never saw them in Bright Moon ever again.

"What do you think?"

"It's-" I struggled for words. "Unimaginable."

"I told you it would be worth it," the green demon said after bringing a child to a burial ground for trapped, starved horde soldiers. In that burial site was a room, a stockpile, filled with every stolen item from every ravaged town that wasn't burnt to the ground. In this room there were pots, rugs, vases, jewels, gold, clothing, bones, crowns, weapons, books, bodies, and, the most beautiful of them all, one painting. The painting consisted of nothing recognizable, nothing conventional, nothing even remarkable, yet it was more mesmerizing than the sun itself. It was massive, framed in a giant gold box. It covered almost the entire wall, and was taller than we were. I could not tell what scene the paint was supposed to be depicting, but it was one I could not imagine took place on this planet, or anywhere in the universe for that matter. The painter must have died, come back to life, and drawn what they saw. Along the edges, parts of the canvas had been ripped off, giving what was left a more rugged, jaded appearance. It was beautiful, as if the tears were part of the artwork to begin with. Moving as if controlled, I stood up and

walked over to the piece. I floated, my hand slowly reaching up, and took a piece off the edge of the painting.

"For your... whatever you're doing."

"Did you paint this?"

"No, I found it in the cave with Auntie."

"Do our parents know that you took it?"

"No, I'm not even writing it in my diary. I don't want anyone finding out, so I'll just make something up." As I presented the ripped painting to Aislin, who had been collecting spare paintings of mine for the past few days, I tried my best to keep what had happened in the cave between us. I didn't want my parents to get worried. I kept up a false smile, walked through the castle like I normally did. Eventually, Double Trouble spilled our secret, and tears with it, and the worst outcome happened. For crimes against the royal family, they were barred from entering the palace grounds ever again. I would see them from time to time, but my mothers, or rather my mother, would never let me have a moment alone with them. I tried to keep thinking about the painting, hoping I would forget the thought of dead bodies, but I would never get the chance to forget what happened that very week. And even if I didn't ever find her body, the last memory I had of Aislin may very well have been that of a corpse.

Death and What it Means

I am dying.

This is not an exaggeration. This is not a plea for help. This is simply a fact.

I am dying, and nothing is going to help me.

This feeling of hopelessness, this utter and final lack of breath, this fading sense of direction and *existence*, I'm only now feeling for myself in its entirety. I don't know what I would call this feeling, nor can I describe it better than I have, but it's more complicated than words can express. It isn't exhaustion, it isn't depression, it's not sad, not lonely, not devastating, not black, not white, not dark or bright or fleeting or new or old or ancient or painful, painless, nothing, something, everything. The feeling is death, and I am feeling it for the first and last time. I would have thought I would think back about my life, all of the choices I made to lead me here at this moment, or think of a better place, like heaven, but I find my brain seeking out one image and one image alone. Aislin. I finally knew what it felt like to be Aislin. She died a decade before I will, and I can finally join her after all this time. Maybe I'll see her, maybe I won't. I probably won't.

It was my birthday. I was thirteen years old, once and once only. The days leading up to this moment were filled with confusion, sorrow, and loss, but the long trudge through was finally over. All of my aunties came, the other queens of other kingdoms, and so did many people I did not know. When you're royalty, people from all around know who you are and care about you and you have never seen them in your life, nor will you ever again. Double Trouble was not at my birthday. The first few hours were hectic, planners and staff members sprinting from side to side, food being cooked, colors being chosen, questions being asked. I didn't see Aislin at all, so I went looking for her. At this point, she was

the only friend I had, and I didn't want to spend too much time without her on this important day.

Aislin stirred in her bed, only just waking up. I had closed the door a little too loudly, but she didn't seem to mind. In fact, she seemed annoyed at the fact that she wasn't awake sooner.

"I don't know why I woke up so late, I never oversleep."

"Really? You always come out of your room after everyone else. You miss breakfast like, five times a week!"

"I know, but I usually just like, sit around my room. I'm not asleep."

We sat for a second, and then I saw her eyes light up ever so briefly. I knew it was finally time to see what she had been working on. I walked out of the room to wait for her to get dressed, where I saw Queen Glimmer was waiting. She wasn't surprised to see me, nor did she seem in a bright mood at all. She was about the only one in the castle who hadn't barraged me with happiness or excitement, instead looked up at me and waved. I waved back and shot a loose smile, she didn't return it. She looked tired. I didn't give her another thought because at that moment Aislin opened her door and beckoned me back inside.

"Okay, so what have you been doing for the last week alone?"

"Follow me."

"No seriously, just tell me!"

"Follow me, you'll find out."

It was no use trying to pry the information out of her, but I thought it was weird to have to follow her somewhere if we were still in her room. It was a big room, mind you, but not big enough for anyone to be followed. It was then that I realized that the window was open. A small, unsteady ladder made its way down from her balcony and onto an enclave of grass. From there, small

paths went all the way down to the bottom of the cliff, down by the docks.

"Are you serious? I'm not climbing down that thing!"

"Well, do you wanna see your birthday gift or not?"

"It's freezing! We'll get frostbite, I don't even have my jacket on!"

"Just take one of mine, I've got tons in my closet."

Eventually, the curiosity took me over, and I grabbed one of her jackets. They were thick and woolen, perfect for keeping in warmth but terrible for climbing down ladders. Thoughts from a few days before, in the tomb, collided around and made my hands shake, but the gloves kept me holding on tight. I hit the ground a few seconds after Aislin, and we both sat there for a second, catching our breath. For a little while we were both silent, apart from our heavy huffs and puffs, and we blended perfectly into the sounds of the wind and the grayness of the landscape. There are no colors in winter.

In my current state of delirium it is hard to focus on the details of what's going on around me. I've seen Serpentine and Serpienta rushing around in various directions, probably in distress, and I've felt water wash over me multiple times. The sky looked gray the last time I saw it, and the air was not cold but not warm. I turned twenty six today, or whatever day it was when I fell and split my head open. That means that I will have spent just as much time with Aislin as I did without her in my life. It doesn't feel like that, obviously because I was a baby for a lot of it, but it's nice knowing that something in this world has a pattern. I've tried hard to see any meaningful motive a God would have for creating us, or what kind of purpose we would play, but I would always end up stumbling into dead ends. This reassures me that something is planned out for us, and that maybe there is a God after all. Maybe the Sea Serpent beneath my body, the Serpent who's life we all saved is looking after me. I saw its eyes once, and although they

were the size of mountains, I knew they were focused on me. I could feel it. Maybe that was when my fate was sealed, when my struggle to stay afloat on this Puny World was ended forever. Thinking this, death does not seem so scary, it feels like home. I've been searching for home every second of every day, just like everything else. My life has been nothing but searching, whether it was life or home or meaning or love or excitement or just pure chance, I've always been bouncing around from place to place, person to person, and I've never felt like I landed until this very moment.

It was not long before the snowstorm hit. The sun was blocked out by thick black clouds and the wind howled like a stray dog. My gift was wonderful, but it was far away. Aislin didn't seem so worried, she just took my hand and slowly started walking towards the palace. I was lost, but she seemed to know where to go. We walked through trees, across rocks, and around beaten paths. Every few steps felt like an alien landscape, especially with the blizzard peppering our vision with white spots, but she never stopped moving. I tried to open my mouth to speak, but my own voice eluded my ears, the wind rushing past too fast to even get out a word. My legs, even through the thick pants, began to seize up and cramp, the cold finally getting to them. I could no longer feel my fingers or toes, and my ears felt like they would fall off at any instant. Still, she kept on moving. She probably would have kept moving forever, but we finally reached the last spot. A river, one we crossed a while earlier to get here, was frozen over and lay right in our path. Not stopping or slowing down, Aislin dragged me down the slight hill and onto the sheet of frozen river water. My feet began to slide, but I kept my ground for as long as I could. My knees were almost ready to give out, and my fingers were not even a part of my body anymore. If I had been able to see them, they probably would have been purple. My favorite color. Each step I took on the ice sent a shockwave up my body, raking my head with aches and pains that made my vision turn double and out of focus. Nothing looked like anything anymore, nothing but gray in every direction. Up, down, left, right, sun,

earth, it was all the same. The brutish noise of the wind suddenly became louder, and my right ear exploded in pain, and suddenly went quiet. I fell to the ground and felt myself sliding. I looked at my hand, but realized there was nothing at the other end of it. I had lost Aislin. I tried to get up but my legs finally gave up trying to support my weight. I was exhausted. I called out her name to the nothingness, and of course nothing responded. I began to cry, panic gripping me at every turn. My fingers were cold. My feet were cold. My chest was cold. My heart was cold. My thoughts were even colder. All I knew how to do in that moment was curl up into a ball, hugging myself as tightly as I could muster with the little strength I had left. I thought I was going to die, but after a while, I began wishing I had. Because the snow started hitting me lightly, the wind started billowing weakly, and the sun peaked its head out from behind the storm clouds. Everything turned okay again in what seemed like an instant, but I still didn't get up.

Death does not mean sorrow, it does not mean fear, it does not mean pain, it does not even mean grief. It doesn't bring joy, or relief, or solace, or catharsis. It does not judge, it does not care, it does not forgive. Death means nothing, and nothing means death. And when you die, nothingness is all that makes sense.

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